

victories on the battlefield to erase the shameful memory of Bull Run. Furthermore, McClellan surrounded himself with officers of a similar political and military persuasion. These staunch Union men were, nevertheless, opposed to making emancipation a primary war goal, and were extremely cautious in their conduct of military affairs. Because of the Union Army's respect for seniority, these officers remained influential in the Army of the Potomac long after McClellan had been relieved of command.

In McClellan's view, "radical" war goals that hoped to transform Southern society through the destruction of slavery would make the Civil War a cruel revolutionary struggle, with reunion impossible, and the Union Army demoralized. As he would later lecture his commander-in-chief, "Military power should not be allowed to interfere with the relations of servitude ... A system of policy thus constitutional and conservative, and pervaded by the influences of Christianity and freedom, would receive the support of almost all truly loyal men, would deeply impress the rebel masses and all foreign nations, and it might be humbly hoped that it would commend itself to the favor of the Almighty." McClellan's vision of civil and military policy was defensible, but his own failures as a battlefield general would discredit it.